



NON-FORMAL EDUCATION SESSION

“European ABC: Educational Workshops for Seniors”

Session 2

International Cooperation and the EU’s Role in the World

Scenario Author

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Duration

Approximately 2–2.5 teaching hours (120–150 minutes)

Number of Participants

12–25 people

2. Workshop Objectives

General Objectives

- To develop understanding of international cooperation and the role of the European Union in the world
- To develop the ability to view EU-related issues from different perspectives
- To encourage reflection on the future of European integration

Specific Objectives

- To understand that the European Union is a process of negotiations, compromises, and choices
- To explore different perspectives (citizen, politician, migrant, Member State, candidate country)
- To develop argumentation and opinion-forming skills
- To strengthen empathy and dialogue skills

3. Description of the Target Group

The workshop is intended for adults, especially seniors, who are interested in the role of the European Union in the world and in international cooperation. No special prior knowledge is required — participants’ life experience and willingness to engage in the proposed activities and working methods are considered most important.



4. Working Methods

- Moderated discussion
- Group work
- Brainstorming
- Elements of an interactive lecture

5. Teaching Materials and Resources

- Computers for information search
- Paper sheets and pens
- Whiteboard or flipchart
- Markers
- Clock or timer
- Materials for writing recommendations to EU policymakers

6. Workshop / Session Plan

1. Introduction

- Greeting participants
- Presentation of the workshop objectives and rules (respect, no “right” or “wrong” answers, the right to change one’s opinion)
- Brief overview of the methods and activities used during the session



2. Main Part — Educational Activities

Activity 1: “The European Union in International Politics”

Objectives

- To engage participants
- To use personal experience related to the EU

Activity Description

Participants work in pairs and share reflections about the European Union’s place in the world.

Instructions

The facilitator invites participants to work in pairs and discuss the following questions:

- What do I know about the causes and objectives behind the founding of the European Union?
- How has the role and influence of the European Union in the world changed, and how does or could this affect my life?

After pair work, participants who wish may briefly share their conclusions with the group.

Time: 15 minutes

Materials: None required

Activity 2: Interactive Lecture

“International Cooperation and the EU’s Role in the World: Challenges of the Current Geopolitical Situation”

Objectives

- To demonstrate the complexity of EU decision-making processes
- To explore different perspectives and emotions
- To develop argumentation skills



Activity Description

Participants take part in a simulated European Union “summit meeting” discussing key EU challenges.

Interactive Lecture Plan

What is EU foreign policy, what is its role in international politics, and what will the future of the European Union look like?

The future of the European Union (EU) is moving toward closer integration in the areas of security, defense, and digital transformation in response to geopolitical challenges. Plans include greener energy systems and technological development; however, the main focus will be on strategic autonomy to reduce dependence on external powers and strengthen the EU’s role in the world.

Main Directions for the EU’s Future

- **Security and Defense:** Following Russia’s aggression against Ukraine, the EU has significantly increased investment in common defense policy and military cooperation.
- **Strategic Autonomy:** The goal is to become more independent in energy, technology, and manufacturing in order to ensure economic security.
- **Green Deal and Energy:** The EU continues progressing toward climate neutrality through renewable energy development and nuclear fusion research.
- **Digital Transformation:** Strong emphasis is placed on artificial intelligence regulation and robotics development.
- **Enlargement:** Discussions continue regarding the admission of new member states, which would alter the EU’s structure and decision-making processes.

The European Union:

1. **As a crisis manager** — the EU has continuously faced crises over the past decade, including:
 - the financial crisis and threats to the euro,
 - the migration crisis,
 - Brexit and concerns about a domino effect,



- the COVID-19 pandemic,
- the geopolitical shock caused by the Russia–Ukraine war.

These crises have tested EU unity and leadership and have deeply shaken the foundations built in Europe over decades.

2. **As one of the most successful missions in human history**
3. **As an opportunity for successful development**

Current Priorities within the EU

Strengthening Security

Russia's military aggression against Ukraine has fundamentally changed the security situation in Europe. The EU has adopted multiple sanctions packages against Russia affecting finance, energy, trade, transport, media, and other sectors.

The EU also actively uses the **European Peace Facility**, which supports military assistance to Ukraine and reimburses EU Member States for military aid provided.

Strengthening Energy Independence

Energy independence remains one of the key priorities both nationally and at the EU level. Main areas of action include:

- increasing renewable energy use,
- improving energy efficiency,
- building new interconnections and cross-border cooperation projects.

Climate Change Policy

Climate change mitigation is one of the EU's major long-term priorities. The EU aims to reduce emissions by at least 55% by 2030 and achieve climate neutrality by 2050.

Increasing attention is also paid to:

- biodiversity protection,
- reducing pollution,



- waste management,
- transition to a circular economy.

Strengthening EU Competitiveness

EU economies face inflationary pressure and slower economic growth. The EU focuses on:

- resilient supply chains,
- access to critical raw materials,
- innovation and skills development,
- deepening the Single Market.

EU Economic Recovery

EU Member States cooperate to stimulate long-term competitiveness and prosperity through:

- the 2021–2027 EU budget,
- the Recovery and Resilience Facility,
- investments in green transition, digitalization, healthcare, education, and equality.

The EU as a Stronger Global Actor

Key priorities include:

- implementing the EU Strategic Compass,
- strengthening resilience and defense industries,
- military mobility,
- combating hybrid threats, disinformation, and cyberattacks,
- cooperation with NATO.

The EU also supports a rules-based international order and enlargement policy based on clear criteria.



EU Development Cooperation Policy

Development cooperation is one of the EU's key external policy areas alongside security, trade, environment, and climate policy.

The EU:

- supports sustainable development, democracy, human rights, and the rule of law worldwide,
- provides more than 50% of global development assistance together with Member States,
- follows the principles of the UN 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development.

Five Priorities of EU Development Policy

1. **People** — human development and dignified living conditions
2. **Prosperity** — inclusive and sustainable growth
3. **Planet** — environmental protection and climate action
4. **Peace** — democracy, human rights, migration, and rule of law
5. **Partnerships** — cooperation among governments, municipalities, private sector, and civil society

EU Financial Instruments and Funding Opportunities

The EU provides assistance through several financial instruments. The main external financing instrument for 2021–2027 is the:

Neighbourhood, Development and International Cooperation Instrument (NDICI) — “Global Europe”

It includes:

1. **Geographical programmes**
2. **Thematic programmes**
3. **Rapid response actions for crises and peacebuilding**

The instrument allows flexible responses to crises and post-crisis situations worldwide.



Activity 3: Discussion and Reflection

Objectives

- To deepen reflection
- To promote understanding of the challenges addressed by the EU in Europe and globally

Activity Description

Group discussion after the session.

Instructions

The facilitator asks:

- Did I gain new information or deepen my understanding during the session?
- Is the European Union a sustainable model for addressing today's geopolitical challenges?

Time: 20 minutes

Materials: Flipchart

3. Conclusion and Reflection

Participants work together in groups of five to create and write down:

“Senior Citizens’ Recommendations for Strengthening EU Foreign Policy and Ensuring European Security”

This document summarizes participants’ key conclusions, values, and recommendations (1–2 pages).

Time: 30 minutes

7. Session Evaluation

- Short concluding discussion
- Evaluation questions (e.g., what was most valuable, what surprised participants)
- Optional anonymous short survey



8. Recommendations

- Continue sessions as a series of meetings
- Explore individual topics in greater depth:
 - migration,
 - EU security guarantees,
 - EU enlargement,
 - possible EU fragmentation models,
 - cooperation opportunities
- Organize similar workshops for different age groups